

Good research begins long before data are collected. It begins with curiosity--a willingness to notice what others overlook and to ask better questions about the world we inhabit. From that spark, the researcher's task is to shape a coherent plan of inquiry that can produce trustworthy knowledge.

A useful way to think about research design is as a series of decisions that connect one another. Each decision constrains the next, and together they determine the quality of the questions we can answer. Clarity at the early stages saves time later and helps us be honest about what our study can and cannot show.

Start with the question. A well-formed research question is specific, feasible, and meaningful. It guides the choice of data, the methods of collection, and the standards for judging results.

Next, consider the theoretical lens. Our perspectives shape what we see and how we interpret it. Being explicit about assumptions does not weaken a study--it strengthens it by making the reasoning visible.

Finally, align methods with questions. No single method fits every question. The art of research is choosing tools that match the problem, the context, and the kind of evidence needed to draw a confident conclusion.

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